

THE VELVET BOOK



COMBAT ZINE

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fear Not

By far the most common questions fielded by new players of *The Velvet Book* involve the game's Combat engine. This is expected: the game has an intentionally crunchy and sometimes intricate system of adjudicating fights between Personas and Shadows, because we feel that it gives the most exciting and compelling gameplay experience. Even still, it daunts some players and on occasion chases them off into other, less technically involved tabletop platforms.

This volume aims to aid Players get a more intuitive understanding of the Combat rules articulated in Chapters 6 and 10 of *The Velvet Book*. It contains a stripped down and easy to parse set of descriptions for formal mechanics of battle to help new players get a better understanding of the game's unique rules as well as to serve as a handy quick reference for veteran players as needed.



The Phases of Combat

PHASE 1: DECLARE

All Fighters say what they're going to do during that Round.

PHASE 2: ROLL

All Fighters roll their Dice and create the Sets that they will use for their Actions.

PHASE 3: RESOLVE

Each Fighter's Actions occur based on their Speed, starting with the fastest action and then counting down to the slowest.

NEXT ROUND

If both sides still have active fighters left standing the Encounter progresses to the next Round and the Phases start again.

ENDING THE FIGHT

The Players win when their enemies are reduced to 0 HP on all Parts; when they Surrender or Flee; or when all of their Parts capable of Attacking are destroyed, allowing the Players to end the Encounter with an All-Out Attack.

The Players lose when their Personas are all reduced to 0 HP on all Parts; when they Surrender or Flee; or when an objective necessary for successfully winning the Fight cannot be accomplished, such as protecting a VIP or winning the fight in a set time period.

Declare

During the Declare Phase, each Fighter says what they are going to do for that Round.

For Humans they will Declare an action using a **STAT + SKILL**.

For Personas, Shadows, and other Non-Human Entities they will Declare an Action using a Quality on one of their Parts: **ATTACK, DEFEND, USEFUL, HEAL, AILMENT**.

DECLARE ORDER

Fighters Declare their Actions in order based on their level of tactical insight.

For Persona Users and other Humans, they use the sum of their **KNOWLEDGE + OUT-THINK**.

For Shadows and other Non-Humans, they use the dice pool of the Part containing their **BRAINS**.

LOWER NUMBERS DECLARE BEFORE HIGHER NUMBERS.

If there's a tie between Persona Users, the Players decide who Declares first. In the event of a tie involving Shadows, the GM will determine who goes first based upon the level of danger posed by the encounter.



Roll

All Fighters roll their dice at the same time and present their Sets to the table.

Humans roll the total dice pool of their **STAT + SKILL**.

Personas, Shadows, and other Non-Human fighters roll the dice pool for the **PART** they are using for their Action.



Resolve

The Actions linked to the Fighters' Sets Resolve based on each Set's **SPEED**.

Speed is based on **WIDTH** plus any Ranks of **FAST** on the Quality used for that Action.

Actions with more Speed occur ahead of Actions with less Speed.

WHEN ACTIONS HAVE EQUAL SPEED, THE HIGHER SET GOES FIRST.

IF BOTH SPEED AND HEIGHT ARE EQUAL, THEY OCCUR SIMULTANENOUSLY.

EXAMPLE

Makoto, Yukari, Ken, and Aigis are fighting a group of Shadows: 2 Slimes, an Oni, and a Pixie. After Declaring and rolling they have the following results:

Makoto: 2x5	Slime A: 2x8
Yukari: 2x7	Slime B: 2x4
Ken: 3x5	Oni: 3x5
Aigis: 3x2 (Fast x1)	Pixie: 2x8 (Fast x1)

These actions resolve as follows:

1. Aigis goes first with a Speed of 4
2. Next is the Pixie; her speed of 3 matches Ken's, but her Height is better.
3. Then Ken and the Oni act at the same time
4. Slime A goes next
5. Followed by Yukari
6. Makoto is next
7. Slime B goes last.

Attack

If a Fighter declares an **ATTACK** they are using their Set to inflict Damage on an opponent.

DAMAGE

AN ATTACK'S DAMAGE EQUALS ITS WIDTH-1

Each Rank of **POWER** on an Attack Quality or Weapon adds 1 to its Damage.

Each Rank of **TOUGH** on the Part your Attack hits reduces Damage by 1.

AGAINST HUMANS, Damage reduces their Stats. Humans Damage is gauged as **SHOCK** from unserious and non-lethal sources, and **SCARS** from severe or life threatening sources.

AGAINST PERSONAS AND SHADOWS, Damage reduces the **HIT POINTS (HP)** of their Parts. They do not differentiate Shocks and Scars.

HIT LOCATION

An Attack Set's Height determines where on the Target it hits.

Against Human opponents, Hit Locations correspond to different Stats.

Against Personas and Shadows, Hit Locations correspond to their **PARTS**.

EXAMPLE

A Jack Frost has the following Parts and Hit Locations:

- (1-5) Icy Body
- (6-10) Impish Face

An Attack with a Height of 4 will target its Icy Body, while an attack with a Height of 9 hits its Impish Face

HITSTUN

If a Fighter is hit by an Attack before they're able to Resolve their own Attack Set, they take **HITSTUN**. Each point of Hitstun knocks 1 die off their Highest or Widest unresolved Attack Set.

If an Attack Set is reduced to 1x Width it is **BROKEN** and cannot be used.

If a Fighter Rolls more two or more Sets and one is Broken from Hitstun, they can use another Set as an Attack instead. This is called a **BACKUP ATTACK SET**.

Each Rank of **HEAVY** on an Attack Quality will cancel 1 point of Hitstun each Round.

DESTROYING PARTS

If a Part's HP reaches 0 it is **DESTROYED** and cannot be used.

Weakness and Resistance

WEAKNESS

If an Attack strikes a Target's Elemental **WEAKNESS** it inflicts bonus damage equal to its Width.

Additionally, an Attack that hits a Weakness never deals less damage its Width, no matter how Tough the Target is.

Finally, hitting a Weakness triggers **ONE MORE!**

EXAMPLE

Makoto's Persona Orpheus hits a Jack Frost with a 2x5 Fire Attack.

This would normally deal 1 Damage. However, because Jack Frost has a Fire Weakness Orpheus adds +2 Damage from its Width, for a total of 3 Damage.

On the next Round, Makoto rolls the same set, but this time Jack Frost's 5 Location has been buffed with Tough x3 from one of its allies.

Usually this would mean Orpheus's 3 Fire Damage is reduced to 0, but since Jack Frost is Weak to Fire it still takes Damage equal to Orpheus's Width, which is 2 Damage.

RESISTANCE

If an Attack strikes a Target's Elemental **RESISTANCE** it can never deal more damage than its Width, no matter how much Power it has.

Furthermore, Fighters do not take Hitstun from Attacks that they Resist.

EXAMPLE

Akihiko's Persona Polydeuces hits a Titania with a 2x8 Electric Attack with Power x4.

This would ordinarily deal 5 Damage. However, because Titania has an Electric Resistance, Polydeuces' Damage cannot exceed its Width, so it only deals 2 Damage.

Making matters worse, Titania takes no Hitstun from this Attack, allowing her to land her 2x7 Attack which would otherwise have been broken by Polydeuces' Attack.

Defend

If a Fighter Declares to **DEFEND** they are using their Set to dodge, block, or otherwise cancel an opposing Fighter's Attack.

Each die in a Defends Set becomes a **GOBBLE DIE** that can Gobble dice from an Attack Set of equal or lower Height and Speed.

If an Attack's Set is Gobbled down to 1x Width it is **BROKEN** and cannot be used.

BREAKING MULTIPLE ATTACKS

A Defends Set's dice can be split apart and used to Break multiple Attack Sets coming at the Defender, as long as it is Fast and High enough.

Unless a Defender uses Multiple Actions they can only use one Set to Defend against all incoming Attacks

EXAMPLE

Aigis commands her Persona Palladion to Defend against incoming Attacks from two enemy Shadows. The Shadows roll 2x5 and 2x7 attacks, and Palladion rolls a 2x9.

Palladion is able to split her 2x9 to Gobble one die from each of the two Sets coming at her, reducing them to 1x5 and 1x7 and breaking both.

In a subsequent Round Aigis makes the same order and rolls a 2x8. She's faced with a 2x5 and a 2x4 with Fast x1. Palladion is able to block the 2x5, but

DEFENDING ALLIES

A Fighter can also Declare a Defends Action to protect one of their Allies from Attack instead of themselves.

Alternatively, a Defends Quality with the **AREA** Extra allows its Set's Gobble Dice to protect one additional Fighter per Rank.

TILTING

If a Fighter is hit by an Attack they can choose to relocate the Damage to a different Part that has a Defends Quality installed. This is called **TILTING**.

Tilting bypasses the Defender's Resistance and cuts any Toughness on the Part in half. Other Extras like Recoil are unaffected.

her 2x8 is too slow to react to the 2x4 at Speed 3, and so she is hit by the Attack.

In the final Round, Aigis Defends a third time and rolls a 3x7. This time she faces four Attack Sets: 2x1, 2x4, 2x5, and 2x7. With her 3x7 Palladion elects to block the three highest Sets, but does not have enough Gobble dice remaining to block the 2x1.

Rally Dice

When a Fighter Declares and Rolls a Defends Set, any unused Gobble Dice leftover at the end of the Round become **RALLY DICE** in the next Round. These represent the advantage in tactical positioning and momentum generated by a successful defensive action.

THE DEFENDER'S ALLIES can claim Rally Dice as +1d bonuses on their Roll. No single Player can claim more than +3d in this manner.

THE DEFENDER can also claim Rally Dice in this manner, but also has other options.

- A Defender can spend unclaimed Rally Dice to cancel 1 Hitstun each
- A Defender can spend unclaimed Rally Dice to cancel 1 Damage each

Unlike using Rally Dice as Bonus Dice rule there is no limit on how many Rally Dice can be used for these two effects.

If a Defender uses Multiple Actions to generate two or more usable Defends Sets in one Round, only one Set can be used to generate Rally Dice.

EXAMPLE

Junpei commands his Persona Hermes to Defend against a powerful incoming Attack. He rolls exceptionally well, picking up a 5x8. The Shadow attacking him rolls a 2x6 and a 2x3. Junpei is able to Break both sets using only two Gobble Dice from his 5x8, leaving 3 remaining. At the end of the Round these become 3d in Rally Dice.

In the following Round Junpei gives 1d Rally Die to Yukari to strengthen her Persona's Attack, and holds onto the others. During that Round this proves to be effective as Junpei rolls a 3x8 Attack but is outpaced by the enemy's 2x8 with Fast x2. Junpei uses both of his unclaimed Rally Dice to reduce the attack's damage by 1 and cancel Hitstun he'd otherwise take, which allows his 3x8 to connect with full power.

Perfect Defense

If your Defends's Set successfully Breaks all of your Opponent's Attack Sets, you have a chance to score a **PERFECT DEFENSE** if either of the following conditions are met:

- **YOUR DEFENDS SET'S HEIGHT BEATS YOUR FOE'S HIGHEST ATTACK SET BY 3 OR MORE.**
Natural Height means the numbers on the dice themselves, ignoring the Effective Extra that can increase a Defends Set's Height by +2 per Rank as well as any other effect that might modify Height.
- **YOUR DEFENDS SET HAS A NATURAL HEIGHT OF x10.** Even if your Attacker is wielding a 2x10, you still score a Perfect Defense if your Defends dice come up with a 2x10 of their own.

ONLY SUCCESSFUL DEFENSES CAN BE PERFECT. If even one Attack Set gets through, no matter its Height, a Defender is denied a Perfect Defense.

Scoring a Perfect Defense awards the Defender **ONE-MORE!**



Useful

If a Fighter declares a **USEFUL** Action they are using one of their Persona's **USEFUL QUALITIES** to affect the battle in some meaningful way-- usually either to bolster themselves or their allies or hinder their enemies.

UNIQUE EFFECTS

Every Useful Quality has its own unique effect that only it or Qualities similar to it can do. Chapter 4 of *The Velvet Book*, **USEFUL THINGS**, details each of these. In addition, Players and GMs are encouraged to create their own once they feel confident in their understanding of how Combat works in this game.

BASIC MOVES

Along with their Unique Effects, there are four **BASIC MOVES** that any Useful Quality can carry out, provided the Player or GM explains how they do so.

1- CREATE AN ADVANTAGE

GENERATE WIDTH IN BONUS DICE by creating a favorable circumstance or event within the battle. Players from your team may claim these bonus dice by explaining how they use the Advantage to improve their abilities.

2- COUNTER OTHER USEFULS

REVERSE OR NEGATE ENEMY USEFUL QUALITIES by describing how your Useful Quality beats theirs. The only Qualities this doesn't work on are the game's standard **BUFFS AND DEBUFFS**, which have their own rules for removal.

3- GRANT NEW EXTRAS

GIVE YOURSELF WIDTH IN EXTRAS OF YOUR CHOOSING FOR ONE ROUND, provided you explain how the Useful Quality does so. These install themselves *right* at the start of the Round before any other actions occur, so you can use them immediately.

4- SOLVE A PROBLEM

OVERCOME A STRATEGIC OBSTACLE IN THE ENCOUNTER, usually something making the Players' lives harder or that's required for success in the battle.

USEFUL EXCELLENCE

If you roll a Useful Set with a Natural (i.e. unmodified by Effectiveness) of 8 or higher you earn **ONE-MORE!**

Bufs and Debufs

BUFFS AND DEBUFFS are a special category of Useful Qualities that Persona and Shadow power in certain ways related specifically to attack potency.

Bufs and Debufs have **DURATIONS** based upon the Width of the Set activating them. These are measured in **ACTIONS** than in Rounds.

B U F F S

RAKUKAJA

Grants the Target Tough x2 against the next Width-1 Attacks.

SUKUKAJA

Grants the Target Fast x2 to its next Width-1 Actions.

TARUKAJA

Grants the Target Power x2 to its next Width -1 Attacks.

OVERWRITING

Bufs are not additive with themselves. You can't stack Tarukaja on someone until they get Power x20. It always gives Power x2.

IF A BUFF OR DEBUFF'S TARGET IS ALREADY UNDER THAT EFFECT, THE DURATION IS OVERWRITTEN. If you have Rakunda vs 1 Attack and get hit by 4 Width-1 worth of Rakunda, your duration is now 3 Attacks.

D E B U F F S

RAKUNDA

Causes the Target to take +2 Damage from the next Width-1 Attacks

SUKUNDA

Causes the Target's next Width-1 Actions to occur at -2 Speed.

TARUNDA

Causes the Target's next Width-1 Attacks to deal 2 less Damage.

REMOVAL

A Buff can be removed by its corresponding Debuff, and vice-versa.

Additionally, the **REFRESH** Useful Quality can remove any Debuff, and the **REVOKE** Useful Quality does the same for Buffs.

Bufs and Debufs are unaffected by all other Useful Qualities

One More!

ONE MORE! is a free Multiple Action awarded to a Fighter as a reward for doing well in Combat.

It allows you to use an unused Set for any Action you choose.

If you don't have an unused Set, One More! gifts you a free 2x1 to use.

ONE MORE! ACTIONS OCCUR IMMEDIATELY AFTER THE ACTION THAT SCORED THEM. It doesn't matter how much speed the Set would normally have, it goes off right away before anything else happens that Round.

There are three ways to score One More!

- 1. ATTACK A SHADOW'S WEAKNESS OR DESTROY ONE OF ITS PARTS BY REDUCING IT TO 0 HP**
- 2. EXECUTE A PERFECT DEFENSE**
- 3. ROLL A USEFUL SET WITH A NATURAL HEIGHT OF 8 OR MORE**

You can score One More! multiple times in a single Round if you qualify for the above actions and have the Sets to support it. You can only get one free 2x1 Set though, so if you cash that in and manage to score another One More! you're out of luck.

Below are your options for what you can do when you score One More!

KNOCKDOWN YOUR TARGET

This Targets the Shadow that you scored One More! on. Knockdown inflicts Width-1 in Hitstun and knocks them prone for Width-1 Rounds. Anyone Attacking a Knocked-Down combatant gets a +1d Bonus. Downed fighters can stand back up early, but doing so consumes their Action for that Round.

ATTACK ANOTHER TARGET

You can't use One More! to attack the same foe twice, but other adversaries are fair game.

OTHER ACTIONS

You can use a One More! Set to activate a Useful Quality, Defend yourself or an ally, or anything else in your repertoire.

REMOVE AN AILMENT

If you're suffering from Ailment, a One More! Set can cleanse it from your system.

PASS THE BATON

This grants Width-1 in Awesome to an Ally of your choice.

Area Attacks

Attack Qualities with the **AREA** Extra installed are capable of damaging every Enemy on the Battlefield.

Area Attacks use **AREA DICE** to inflict Damage.

EACH FIGHTER TARGETTED BY AN AREA ATTACK ROLLS WIDTH-1 + AREA RANKS IN AREA DICE

Each Target then takes 1 Damage to each Location indicated by the Area Dice they rolled.

EXAMPLE

Mitsuru's commanders her Persona Pentheseia to blast a group of three Shadows using Attack (Ice, Area x3). She rolls a 2x7, so each Shadow must roll 4d Area Dice:

Shadow A: (1,3,4,8)

Shadow B: (3,7,10,10)

Shadow C: (1, 4, 5, 9)

Each Shadow takes 1 point of Damage to each Hit Location indicated by their Area Dice.

REACTING TO AREA ATTACKS

Defending against an Area Attack doesn't stop it from going off, it just shields *you* or whoever you're covering from the damage. Anyone left undefended will still be Hit if it goes off.

Putting Area on your Defends Quality can help, as it lets your Defends Set cover multiple allies.

As an emergency measure you can roll Defend at a -1d Penalty to **JUMP ON THE GRENADE**. This protects all your allies from the Attack at the cost of you absorbing all the Area Dice intended for them.

Area Attacks can also be stopped with Hitstun.

OTHER INTERACTIONS

POWER: Each Rank of Power installed on an Area Attack lets it ignore 1 Rank of Tough.

HITSTUN: Area Attacks only inflict Hitstun if they successfully inflict Damage.

WEAKNESS/RESISTANCE: Area Attacks ignore *all* Toughness on Targets weak to their Element. If a Target Resists an Area Attack's Element its Area Dice pool is halved.

BUFFS/DEBUFFS: When the Raku- and Taru-effects are in play you add or subtract Area Dice as you would Damage on a regular attack.

ONE MORE! You can only score a single One More! with an Area Attack, even if multiple Weaknesses are hit or Parts are Destroyed.

Heal

A Fighter Declaring to **HEAL** is using the Quality of the same name to restore lost HP to themselves to an ally.

A PERSONA CAN USE A HEAL RANK TO RESTORE 2 HP TO A TARGET

You can use as many Ranks of Healing as you want at once to Heal as much HP as you are able. A Persona with Heal x4 can restore up to 8 HP, and they can choose to do it four times for 2 HP each, or one time for all 8 HP

When you Heal a Fighter other than yourself they choose where to apply the HP.

LIMITED USES

EACH USE OF HEALING EXPENDS ONE OF THE PERSONA'S HEAL RANKS. When all Ranks of a Healing Quality are spent it's no longer usable for the rest of that Combat.

EFFECTIVE HEALING

Each Rank of **EFFECTIVE** on a Heal Quality lets it Heal +1 HP per Rank. Thus Heal x2 (Effective x 3) can heal 5 HP twice per Combat.

HEALING NEVER FAILS

YOU DON'T NEED TO ROLL A SET TO HEAL.

Rolling a Set only affects the Action's **TIMING**. If you don't roll a Set then the Healing occurs at the end of the Resolve Phase of that Round, after all other Actions have occurred.

AREA HEALING

Each Rank of **AREA** on a Heal Quality lets you Heal one additional Target at a time. If you have Heal x2 (Effective x1, Area x1) you can Heal 3 HP twice per Encounter, and that HP can be distributed to up to 2 Targets at a time at your discretion.

HEALING AILMENTS

You may spend a Heal Rank to remove any Ailment from a Target.

REVIVING PARTS

If a Part has been reduced to 0 HP you can use one Heal Rank to restore it to 1 HP. Effectiveness doesn't modify this.

You can also use the **REVIVE** Useful Quality to bring back a Destroyed part, giving it HP equal to Width + any Heal Ranks on your Persona, event spent ones. The full rules for this Quality can be found on Page 165 of *The Velvet Book*.

OVERHEALING

Any Healing performed on a Target that exceeds their max HP increases their HP for the duration of the Encounter.

Overheal HP only last for the duration of the Encounter, and evaporates afterwards.

Healing out of Combat

HAVE A SHORT REST

While traversing the Other World, HP Recovery can be accomplished out of Combat by taking a **SHORT REST** and using a **GROUP RECOVERY ACTION**.

Group Recovery uses a combination of the collective Healing of the Party and the results of one Persona's Useful Quality rolls to patch up damage and restore morale and fighting spirit. Any Useful Quality can be used as long as you explain how it benefits the Party.

GROUP RECOVERY HEALS HP TO EACH PERSONA EQUAL TO THE USEFUL SET'S WIDTH + THE TOTAL HEAL RANKS SHARED BY THE PARTY'S PERSONAS.

TIME COST

EACH TIME SLOT CAN SUSTAIN 2 SHORT RESTS. If the Players decide to take a third Short Rest for more healing the game will advance to the next Time Slot. If this happens any Useful Qualities with limited uses per Time Slot will be refreshed.

EXAMPLE

After battling through Tartarus for what feels like ages but is actually just 20 minutes, the SEES Team of Makoto, Mitsuru, Yukari, and Koromaru take a Short Rest on an unoccupied floor of the tower.

Koromaru uses his Persona Cerberus's *Control Fire* Useful Quality to create a comforting campfire for the Party to gather around and warm themselves in front of. He rolls a 3x8 and combines it with Yukari's Io Persona's Heal x4 to restore 7 HP to each Persona.

Having used one Short Rest, the SEES Team can take just one more within their Time Slot. If they try to do so a third time it will result in the Dark Hour ending and the team being returned to the Real World.

FAVORITE THING HEALING

Once per Time Slot, you can Heal your Persona by indulging its **FAVORITE THING**. This can be done in the Other World or the Real World. How much HP you recover is based on your dedication to the Favorite Thing:

MINOR DEDICATION: 1 HP

SIGNIFICANT: Half its Total Damage

MAJOR: All Damage

Ailments

AILMENTS can act as either as their own Qualities, or as Extras installed on Attacks. This changes how they are inflicted on your enemies, but their behavior is the same once you do so.

AILMENT QUALITIES

An **AILMENT QUALITY** inflicts a specific Ailment on a Target for Width -1 + Ailment Rank in Rounds.

AILMENT ATTACKS

An Attack Quality with an **AILMENT EXTRA** installed on it has a chance to inflict that Ailment when it successfully hits a Target.

Roll one **AILMENT DIE** for each Rank of the Ailment on the Attack; each die that rolls a 6 or higher inflicts 1 Round of the Ailment.

EXAMPLE

Ken's Persona Nemesis has the Quality Ailment: Crush x2 one of its Parts. Ken rolls a 2x7 to use this Quality to inflict Crush on a Shadow for 3 turns by burying it under a pillar of intense gravimetric pressure.

Koromaru's Persona Cerberus has Attack (Fire, Ailment: Burn x2). It attacks a Shadow and successfully hits with a 3x5. Koromaru rolls 2d Ailment Dice and gets a (2, 8). In addition to dealing Fire damage, the Shadow is now Burning for 1 Round.

BANE

Removes one of its Target's Resistances.

BURN/BLEED/POISON

The Target takes 2 Damage after their Actions Resolve. This Damage is applied to whatever Part was hit by the Ailment Set, and it ignores Toughness. If the Part is reduced to 0 HP before its Duration ends the Ailment passes to an adjacent Part.

CRUSH

Every time the Target performs an Action they take 1 Damage to the Part they used.

DAZE

Reduces the Height of all Sets by 2, and any Sets with Height of 2 or less fail. Disables Always Works Extras.

FREEZE

The Target has all Ranks of Fast reduced by 1, and they take +1 Damage from Physical Attacks.

STATIC

The Target takes an additional point of Hitstun from all Attacks.

All-Out Attacks

When an enemy group of Shadows can no longer Attack the Persona Users, the Battle can be immediately ended using an **ALL-OUT ATTACK**.

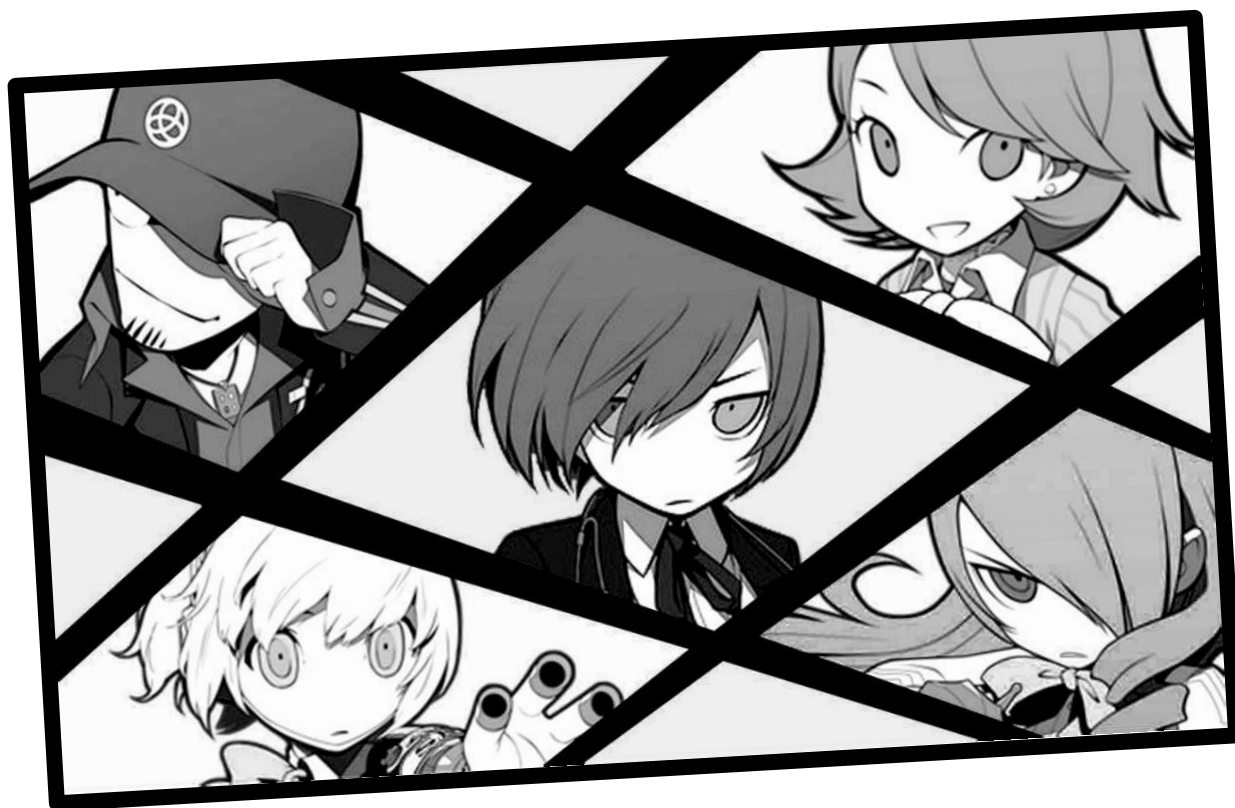
This normally happens when all of their Parts containing Attack Qualities have been Destroyed, leaving the Shadows with no means of Damaging the Players.

THERE ARE NO RULES IN AN ALL-OUT ATTACK

The Players are allowed to dispatch the surviving Shadows in any way they choose.

Be as stylish and over-the-top as you want.

You can even let your Human character take a whack at them if you're so inclined. That works too.



Arcana Boosting

At any time during or out of Combat you can add any amount of **RELATIONSHIP DICE** directly to a Persona's Parts. This is called an **ARCANA BOOST**.

You can add these as raw Dice to improve a Part's dice pool, or as Extras installed on the Persona's Parts and Qualities.

Each Relationship can grant specific Extras based upon its Arcana.

MAGICIAN	Power (Elemental Attacks only)	STRENGTH	Tough
HIGH PRIESTESS	Effective, Heal	HANGED MAN	Tough
EMPRESS	Effective, Area	DEATH	Power (Physical Attacks only)
EMPEROR	Power (Physical Attacks only)	TEMPERANCE	Ailment, Heavy
HIEROPHANT	Effective, Area	DEVIL	Ailment, Heavy
LOVERS	Heal, Recoil	TOWER	Recoil, Area
CHARIOT	Fast	STAR	Effective, Heal
JUSTICE	Fast	MOON	Recoil, Area
HERMIT	Power (Elemental Attacks only)	SUN	Spray
FORTUNE	Heal, Recoil	JUDGEMENT	Spray

Arcana with two Extras can grant either when Arcana Boosting.

For **TEMPERANCE** and **DEVIL** Arcana, they can either increase the Rank of an existing Ailment or install a new Ailment Quality or Extra.

Arcana Boosts expire at the end of the Time Slot they're used in.

FEEDBACK

If a Part that has been Arcana Boosted is Damaged, the Relationship whose dice it absorbed takes **FEEDBACK** Damage.

The total Feedback a Relationship can take from a Part equals the total Dice that Part was boosted with. Add +3d, risk 3 Relationship Shock.

Feedback also ignores Toughness.

EXAMPLE

During a heated Major Shadow Battle, Akihiko uses 3d from his 4d Relationship with the kendo team captain Yuko Nishiwaki as an Arcana Boost.

Yuko's Arcana is Strength, so Akihiko is able to add +1d to one of Polydeuces's Parts, as well as Tough x2 to that Part.

During battle that Part takes a total of 5 damage, resulting in his Relationship with Yuko taking 3 Shock due to Feedback.

Advanced Attacks:

AMPLIFY AND STRAIN

This section covers some special Attack rules detailed in **CHAPTER 10: ADVANCE COMBAT**, as well as some cool tips and tricks for Spray Attacks.

AMPLIFY

AMPLIFY is a special combat Action that can be used with **ELEMENTAL ATTACK QUALITIES**, allowing you to charge up more powerful Elemental Attacks.

When you roll an Amplify Set you can add Width-1 to the Width of your next Attack Set using that Element.

If you use Multiple Actions to Amplify and Attack in the same turn, the Speed of your Amplify Set doesn't matter.

EXAMPLE

Junpei Declares an action to Amplify his Persona Hermes' Fire ability. He rolls a 3x4 using his Attack (Fire) Quality, earning a +2 Width Amplification on his next Fire Attack.

On the next Round he targets a Shadow using Attack (Fire). He rolls a 2x7, which is Amplified with +2 Width, turning it into a 4x7.

STRAIN

STRAIN is a special effect that can be used with **PHYSICAL ATTACK QUALITIES** allowing you to intensify your Attack at the cost of HP.

Each point of Strain Damage you take equals 1 point of **UNBLOCKABLE DAMAGE**. Even if your target has Tough x10 and successfully Defends against your Set, they still take damage. As long as you rolled a Set, the damage goes through.

You can only take **3 HP** worth of Strain per Declared Attack.

You can use Strain **DURING** the Resolve phase. You don't have to Declare it ahead of time, you can do so in the moment, adding extra damage at will.

EXAMPLE

Shinjiro commands his Persona Castor to launch a Physical Attack at a Shadow. He rolls a 3x5 and hits the Shadow at a Part that is Tough x2; ordinarily this would block all of Castor's Damage but Shinjiro adds 3 points of Strain on the attack, allowing Castor to smash through the Shadow's armor for 3 Damage, at the cost of 3 HP to its Attacking Part.

Next Round Castor rolls a 2x5 Physical Attack that is blocked by a Shadow's 2x10 Defends Set. Shinjiro adds 2 Strain to the Attack, driving Castor to push past the Shadow's Defense to deal 2 damage and taking 2 Damage to its Attacking Part.

Advanced Attacks:

SPRAY

Attacks with the **SPRAY** Extra have special timing rules that are useful to understand.

Spray turns one hit into many, either as a rapid sequence of attacks, or a big messy splash that hits one Target over a wide area, or as a continuous stream of damage.

Each Rank of Spray lets you use an additional Set you used as Attacks without declaring Multiple Actions. If you don't have enough Sets you can turn Loose Dice with less Height than your existing Set into functional 1x Width Sets; as Attacks, these can inflict Damage if your Attack Quality has at least Power x1.

TIMING SUPERIORITY

Spray Sets, including activated Loose Dice, go off **IMMEDIATELY** after your fastest Set Resolves.

This means if you use an Attack with Spray x2 and roll a 4x5, a 2x8, and a Loose 3, your 2x8 and Loose 3 will go off immediately after your 4x5 Resolves, even though their speed would normally be much lower.

SPRAY LIMITATIONS

HITSTUN: A Spray Attack only inflicts a single point of Hitstun, no matter how many Sets it connects with.

SINGLE TARGET: All Sets in a Spray Attack must be directed at a single Target. You cannot split them between multiple Foes.

WEAKNESS & RESISTANCE

Loose Spray Dice have a couple important interactions with a prospective Target's Weakness and Resistance

LOOSE SPRAY DICE DON'T SET OFF

WEAKNESSES. If you use an Attack with (Spray x2, Power x1) and hit a Shadow's Weakness with a 3x4, a 2x8, and a Loose 3, your 3x4 and 2x8 Sets will get +3 and +2 Damage bonus respectively from their Widths, but the Loose 3 doesn't get anything. It just deals 1 Damage thanks to its Power x1.

RESISTANCES CANCEL LOOSE SPRAY DICE.

If we use the same example as above but swap the Weakness for a Resistance, the Loose 3 won't hurt the Shadow at all. No matter how much Power the Attack Quality might have, no Loose Spray Die can scratch a Resistant foe.

ESSAY: WHY COMBAT WORKS THE WAY IT DOES

As stated out the outset, Combat in *The Velvet Book* is not a simple affair. It's got a lot of moving parts and enough rules that even this streamlined manual clocks in at 20 pages worth of pure crunch.

It's to my regret that some players have simply bounced off the game because of not being able to grasp Combat, or even just not *liking* how it works and so as development has progressed and the game evolved I've always been on the lookout for ways to simplify and streamline its engines. Yet, at the end of the day, Combat remains a determinedly complex endeavor.

This is, in many ways, on purpose, and I've kept it that way for three reasons.

I LIKE CRUNCHY, VISCERAL COMBAT. As a Player I'm drawn to games that give me lot of buttons to press when swords meet shields, and that present meaningful results when those buttons are pressed. As a GM and Developer, I'm drawn to systems with really robust mechanics for resolving hits and maneuvers, but that don't bog the game down with tedious bookkeeping and multiple rolls for each facet of every action. I like a game where hitting stuff feels *good* and where learning how the mechanics interact with each other feels satisfying.

The One Roll Engine has always done well for me in these respects, and so in writing *The Velvet Book* I made it part of my mission statement to design the most sophisticated version of the Engine's combat aspects. To that end I'm quite proud of what I've developed, and I'd hold it up to any professionally built O.R.E. game on the market, few as there are.

I THINK IT BETTER EVOKES THE FEEL OF PERSONA COMBAT. I say "feel" instead of "the reality of *Persona* Combat" because those are two extremely different things. The reality of how Combat works in the *Persona* video games wouldn't make a very interesting tabletop RPG if its mechanics were perfectly transliterated. You're just picking options from a menu and wiping out squads of Shadows in three moves by using their Weaknesses and All-Out Attacks before certain members of your Party even get to act. That works great for a single player RPG because it rewards you for learning the systems and recognizing patterns, but at a table with other living humans controlling the rest of the Party it would fall apart almost interesting.

But what's more important than what you're doing is what you *feel* like you're doing. The *Persona* video games are successful in making the Player feel like they're unleashing these almighty mythological figures that they can *barely* control to destroy their foes in dramatic and visceral ways, and I think the Combat engine used by *The Velvet Book* captures that feeling.

Finally, **I JUST THINK IT MAKES THE GAME BETTER.** The reader's mileage may vary, but my earnest belief is that the options presented by *The Velvet Book* and the game feel they curate make for a more exciting and rewarding experience. To that end, it's my humble hope that this document has been helpful to any Players finding this facet of the game challenging, and that with it you'll be able to enjoy what I've designed as much as I've enjoyed making it.

- Personanon Press

THE VELVET BOOK COMBAT ZINE



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